

the rich fool when He said, "This very night your soul is required of you; and now who will own what you have prepared?" (Luke 12:20)

PURPOSES FOR INVESTING

A legitimate purpose of any investment program is to help your family achieve greater security. This can include investing to provide for your children's education, to provide a family inheritance, to provide for retirement, and the like. But there are also many nonscriptural reasons for investing: greed, indulgence, and covetousness to name a few.

No single financial plan will fit every family. Unfortunately, today many financial planners tend to lump everybody into one mold. I believe in using financial advisers, and I encourage you to use them also. These include professionals in areas such as legal, accounting, and financial planning. The key is: use them as sources of expertise, not gurus. They can provide alternatives, suggestions, and expert advice, but ultimately the decisions must be yours.

There are basically two types of financial advisers. One gives advice and charges a fee for it. The other sells financial products in the process of giving advice. I consider the latter category more of a salesman than a counselor. Salesmen have a place in the planning process, particularly in selecting investments, but they should not be used as primary counsel. Eventually, they're going to sell you the product they represent. Obviously, they believe in their products and rightly so, but diversity as prescribed in Ecclesiastes 11:2 requires a much broader array of investments than one salesman usually offers.

Even though every family's needs in the area of investing are different, there are certain common principles that can provide a solid foundation for anybody. I hesitate to label anything "1, 2, 3, 4, 5 . . ." because it may take the rest of your life to implement 1 and 2. Nevertheless, I have tried to distill the basic investing principles into 10 keys or guidelines. If you'll read and apply these to your own financial plans, your investment decisions will be much clearer.